a different kind of national achievement this time: the rise of self-made women who are shaping and redefining India's future. These are women who have created their own success stories, with a novel idea, an innovation, a new approach, or the courage to challenge convention—all before hitting the half century mark of their lives. To get here, they have risen above their circumstance, whether of income, education, gender bias, family responsibility and, at times, self-doubt. Across domains as varied as business, science, sport, governance and cinema—they have not only broken barriers but also shown what is possible when women have the freedom to shape their own destinies. For these 50 women under 50, freedom means more than political or constitutional rights—it means economic independence, professional opportunity, creative expression and the freedom to lead. All of which makes them the ideal role models for the nearly 560 million women under 50 in India, 78 per cent of the 715 million women in India, according to UN projections.

Her Time Has Come

The writing is on the wall. Women in India have been ready for a while now to occupy their place in the sun—and mere tokenism will no longer suffice. Their struggle has always been harder, starting from birth (India has historically had an adverse sex ratio for girls) to the right to a school or college education (their literacy rate of 74.9 per cent remains lower than the 87.5 per cent for males). Campaigns such as Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao have gone some way in dispelling darkness, but against the entrenched patriarchy of millennia, they are destined to come up short. Life gets no better in adulthood. The old curse of child marriage persists in the country's rural hinterlands, varying from 20 per cent to 23 per cent, compared to 50 per cent a few decades ago. Crime against women remains a blot on the nation, with 1,210-1,220 such complaints being filed every day, or roughly 51 every hour.

Yet resilience is an attribute hardwired into the Indian woman, and it helps her survive the most overwhelming odds. Nowhere is it more apparent than in sports. The grind begins early, as it did for 21-year-old wrestling champ Antim Panghal, who as a 10-year-old child would wake up every day at six in the morning, travel 20 km from Bhagana in Haryana to train for 3-4 hours and then make the same journey back home. Today, she is world no. 1 in the women's 53 kg category. And who would have known that a girl from the rustic Barki Chhapar in Jharkhand, who'd win goats and chickens for her exploits with the hockey stick at the local games, would one day captain the Indian hockey team. Salima Tete did exactly that.

Success, though, is the visible part of the story. Failure is a lonelier place, and the more familiar one. But women know how to negotiate it too. They perhaps tell themselves what Indian women's cricket star all-rounder Shafali Verma tells others: "Always believe in yourself. There will be difficult times, not everything will go your way, but don't let one setback decide your future." She has been there. Excluded from the team for the 2025 ODI women's World Cup, returning as an injury replacement, and helping India win through fantastic displays with bat and ball.

HOLDING UP HALF THE SKY

715
MILLION
Number of women in India, nearly half the country's population

78
PER CENT
Women less than 50 years old, numbering around 557 million

1.45
MILLION
Elected women representatives in Panchayati Raj Institutions, 46 per cent of the total

Getting Down to Business

Success is not the first thing a woman entrepreneur chases. All she starts with is an idea, born perhaps out of an unmet need, and the conviction to pursue it. For Vineeta Singh, it was the lack of beauty products made for Indian skin tones and capable of withstanding Indian heat and humidity that became the motivation for starting a cosmetics firm, SUGAR. It wasn't easy—Vineeta had to go through rejection by a hundred investors before global private equity firm L Catterton and actor Ranveer Singh put their faith and their money in her brand. Today, she has more than 2,000 self-made women working for her and her company sells 550 products across lips, eye and skin care across 45,000 retail outlets in the country as well as online. Her lesson? "There will be enough people underestimating you. Make sure you're never one of them." In Gurugram, engineering graduate Upasana Taku's quest for a quick and easy online payments system culminated in the hugely successful MobiKwik wallet firm that she and her husband set up together.

The victory of women like Vineeta Singh and Upasana Taku is a victory for all women, as India becomes the second country in the world where women-led start-ups at-